



P. CHIDAMBARAM

64, Home Minister (New)

Security Czar

Because he is the best man for the toughest job.

Becausehe delivered 400 terror-free days until the Pune blasts.

Becausesuch is his credibility that no one blamed the Ministry of Home Affairs for intelligence failure after the Pune blast, not even as bitter a critic as Narendra Modi.

Becausehe is one of the few ministers who bridges the generation gap between the two Gandhis with ease and also enjoys the prime minister's trust.

Becauseonly he can issue stern editorial reprimands to the Naxals, asking them to communicate in simple one-line messages.

Becausewhen he proposes a radical restructuring of the internal security structure, the prime minister promptly agrees.

The inspiration Poet, philosopher Saint Thiruvalluvar. Often quotes a Tamil couplet which he translates as "the world is his who does his job with compassion".

The regret With his career graph at an all-time high, has few regrets except that he "did not study Maths and win the Nobel."

The humility When asked to rate his own performance, a rather humble Chidambaram says it's "pretty close to zero".

POWER READ Likes John Grisham as the characters are usually lawyers. But gets nostalgic about Enid Blyton.

PERSON HE CAN'T SAY NO TO His eight-year-old granddaughter Aditi.

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SHARAD PAWAR

69, Minister of Agriculture, Food and Consumer Affairs, and NCP Chief (6)

Tough Customer

Becausethe prime minister uses him to create consensus among other allies on issues such as the UPA's disinvestment agenda and the move to hike urea prices.

Becausehe refused to become the scapegoat on rising food prices and forced the Cabinet to take 'collective responsibility'.

Becausewhen he wrote a 16-page letter to the prime minister in favour of Bt brinjal, Manmohan Singh called a meeting to discuss his concerns.

Opinion maker He was the first UPA leader to state that his candidate for prime ministership during E-2009 was Manmohan Singh even when some Congressmen were pushing Rahul Gandhi's name.

Should be embarrassed about Supporters who advocate that Indians should stop eating sugar as a solution to the price rise.

Little known fact An atheist, he goes to a temple only when his wife asks him to.

POWER ACT Whenever he meets old friend Bal Thackeray, it upsets political equations in New Delhi.

CARELESS COMMENT When quizzed about the likelihood of prices coming down, he said, "I'm not an astrologer."

